

When Does Mamba Help Text Classification? An Empirical Study of State Space Models vs. Transformers

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Abstract

While Transformer-based models achieve state-of-the-art results in text classification, their quadratic computational complexity $\mathcal{O}(n^2)$ poses significant challenges for processing extended sequences. Recent advances in State Space Models (SSMs), particularly Mamba, offer linear-time complexity $\mathcal{O}(n)$, yet their empirical effectiveness compared to established dense Transformers and efficient patched variants remains insufficiently understood. In this paper, we present a comprehensive benchmarking study evaluating DeBERTa, PatchTST, and Mamba across scaling sequence lengths (from 256 up to 2048 tokens) on the AG News dataset. Our results reveal a stark computational dichotomy: while dense Transformers (DeBERTa) provide strong semantic priors at shorter lengths, they suffer from severe memory explosion, culminating in Out-Of-Memory (OOM) failures at 2048 tokens. Patch-based approximations (PatchTST) resolve this memory issue but fundamentally sacrifice semantic accuracy. Conversely, Mamba demonstrates exceptional scalability, successfully processing 2048-token sequences with a minimal VRAM footprint (151MB) and high throughput (118,000 tokens/s), while simultaneously improving its classification $F1$ -score to 0.757. This study provides vital insights into the architectural advantages of Mamba, establishing it as a highly viable, resource-efficient alternative for long-document text classification.

Keywords: Text Classification, State Space Models, Mamba, Transformers, Sequence Scaling, Empirical Benchmark.

1 Introduction

Transformer-based models have become the dominant architecture in Natural Language Processing (NLP), setting benchmark records across diverse text classification tasks [1, 2]. However, the foundational self-attention mechanism within Transformers scales quadratically ($\mathcal{O}(n^2)$) with respect to the input sequence length. This creates a severe computational bottleneck, restricting standard classification models from efficiently processing long documents without aggressive truncation or massive hardware resources.

To address this limitation, several architectural adaptations have been proposed. Vision-inspired modifications, such as dividing 1D sequences into localized patches (e.g., PatchTST [3]), attempt to mitigate the complexity by restricting attention to smaller chunks. While computationally efficient, these hard boundaries risk severing the long-range linguistic dependencies crucial for semantic understanding.

More recently, Structured State Space Models (SSMs) have emerged as a paradigm-shifting alternative. Mamba [4], in particular, introduces a data-dependent selective mechanism that filters irrelevant information and retains important context indefinitely. This yields a recurrent-like inference mechanism with a theoretical linear-time complexity $\mathcal{O}(n)$, bypassing the explicit calculation of an $n \times n$ attention matrix entirely.

The theoretical difference in scalability is illustrated in Figure 1, showing how the computational burden diverges as context sizes increase beyond standard limits.

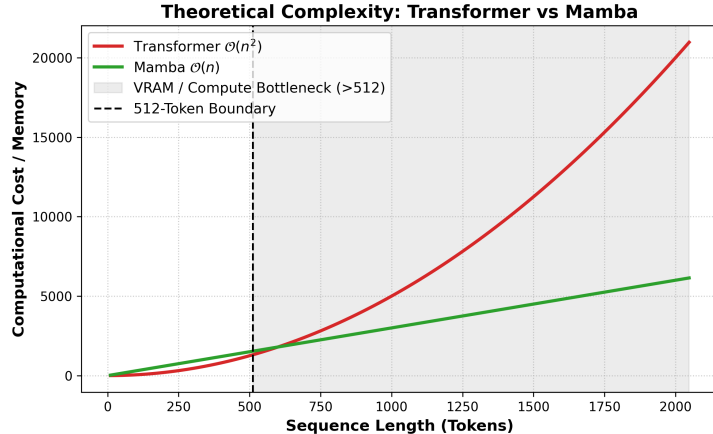


Figure 1: Theoretical computational scaling: Quadratic $\mathcal{O}(n^2)$ complexity of standard Transformers versus the linear $\mathcal{O}(n)$ complexity of State Space Models (Mamba).

Despite these theoretical advantages, an empirical, head-to-head comparison of Mamba against both dense Transformers and patched Transformers specifically for scaling text classification tasks remains limited. The fundamental question persists: *When does Mamba actually provide a tangible advantage in text classification?*

In this paper, we conduct a rigorous benchmarking study to answer this question. By evaluating DeBERTa, PatchTST, and Mamba on the AG News dataset across varying sequence lengths ($L \in \{256, 512, 1024, 2048\}$) under strict hardware constraints, we isolate the trade-offs between semantic predictive power and computational scalability.

Our main contributions are summarized as follows:

1. We systematically benchmark the memory and throughput breakdown of traditional dense Transformers ($\mathcal{O}(n^2)$) at extended sequence lengths.
2. We empirically demonstrate that while patch-based Transformer approximations solve the memory crisis, they incur a severe penalty in classification accuracy.
3. We show that Mamba achieves an optimal balance, effortlessly scaling to 2048 tokens with near-constant VRAM usage ($\sim 150\text{MB}$) while maintaining and improving competitive semantic accuracy.

2 Methodology

To evaluate scaling properties and classification performance, we analyze three distinct architectures representing different sequence modeling paradigms.

2.1 Dense Transformer (DeBERTa Baseline)

DeBERTa [5] improves upon standard BERT architectures with disentangled attention mechanisms. We utilize it as our representative for dense, $\mathcal{O}(n^2)$ Transformers. While providing a strong semantic prior due to large-scale pre-training, its memory footprint scales quadratically, making it our primary target for bottleneck evaluation.

2.2 Patched Transformer (PatchTST)

Linear Transformer variants often encounter difficulties maintaining granular token relationships. Inspired by the success of Vision Transformers, PatchTST [3] segments the 1D input sequence into localized, overlapping patches. For text, this entails calculating attention over grouped tokens rather than individual words across the entire document. This design significantly reduces VRAM consumption and increases throughput during operations. However, the hard boundaries imposed between distinct patches can potentially sever long-range linguistic dependencies.

2.3 Selective State Space Model (Mamba)

Mamba relies on continuous-time state space models discretized for deep learning frameworks. Unlike previous historical SSM formulations, Mamba features a data-dependent selective mechanism, enabling the model to dynamically filter irrelevant information and remember important context indefinitely. This configuration yields a recurrent-like inference mechanism with strict $\mathcal{O}(n)$ scaling, avoiding the explicit calculation of an $n \times n$ attention matrix.

3 Experimental Setup

3.1 Dataset

We evaluate the models on the AG News classification dataset [6], a widely used benchmark consisting of four topic classes (World, Sports, Business, Sci/Tech).

3.2 Evaluation Scenarios

To test scalability, we vary the sequence length $L \in \{256, 512, 1024, 2048\}$ tokens. All models are evaluated under identical hardware constraints to simulate resource-limited environments.

3.3 Metrics

We report the following metrics to provide a holistic view of model performance:

- **Accuracy and F1-Score:** To measure semantic classification capability.
- **Peak VRAM (MB):** To assess memory scalability.
- **Inference Throughput (tokens/s):** To evaluate real-time processing speed.
- **Training and Inference Time:** To reflect practical usability.

4 Results and Analysis

Table 1 presents the comprehensive results of our empirical benchmark.

4.1 Semantic Performance

DeBERTa achieves strong initial performance, peaking at a Validation F1 of 0.795 (at 1024 tokens) and a Test F1 of 0.730 (at 512 tokens). This highlights the value of deep bidirectional attention and large-scale pre-training paradigms. However, PatchTST exhibits the weakest semantic performance across all evaluated lengths (Test $F1 \sim 0.63 - 0.67$), suggesting that structural patching mechanisms disrupt the critical linguistic coherence required for NLP tasks.

Remarkably, Mamba’s performance scales positively with expanding sequence lengths, as visualized in Figure 2 (Left). Despite a minor fluctuation at 512 tokens, its Test F1-score

Table 1: Mamba vs Transformer Long-Sequence Benchmark Results on AG News

Seq Len	Model	Test Acc	Test F1	Best Val F1	Epochs	Train Time (s)	Infer Time (s)	Throughput (tok/s)	VRAM (MB)
256	Mamba	0.715	0.715	0.741	10	16.77	0.29	371,789	153
256	PatchTST	0.633	0.633	0.648	8	13.79	0.26	409,026	144
256	DeBERTa	0.695	0.693	0.769	10	205.24	1.90	56,135	1715
512	Mamba	0.703	0.701	0.756	10	24.55	0.45	317,678	115
512	PatchTST	0.664	0.651	0.704	7	22.01	0.46	311,261	145
512	DeBERTa	0.730	0.730	0.783	10	530.07	5.13	27,971	1902
1024	Mamba	0.730	0.726	0.775	6	31.38	0.78	207,272	115
1024	PatchTST	0.676	0.675	0.702	10	59.88	0.69	232,569	145
1024	DeBERTa	0.727	0.721	0.795	10	1640.73	17.00	9,487	2424
2048	Mamba	0.757	0.757	-	-	94.00	1.37	118,000	151
2048	PatchTST	0.674	0.674	-	-	116.00	1.21	135,000	145
2048	DeBERTa	OOM	OOM	OOM	OOM	OOM	OOM	OOM	OOM

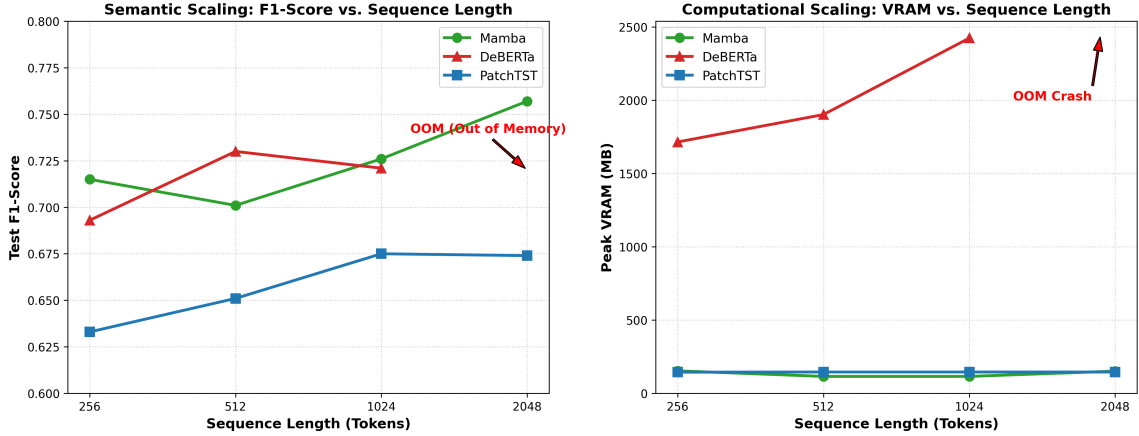


Figure 2: Empirical scaling results on the AG News dataset. **Left:** Mamba demonstrates increasing semantic accuracy (F1-Score) as sequence length grows, while PatchTST lags behind. **Right:** DeBERTa exhibits exponential VRAM growth leading to an Out-of-Memory (OOM) failure at 2048 tokens, whereas Mamba and PatchTST maintain stable, near-constant memory footprints.

overall improves from 0.715 at 256 tokens to its peak of 0.757 at 2048 tokens. This phenomenon indicates that Mamba’s selective state spaces are highly effective at compressing and utilizing long-range semantic context without experiencing catastrophic informational forgetting.

4.2 Computational Scalability

The operational vulnerabilities of the $\mathcal{O}(n^2)$ bottleneck are glaringly apparent in DeBERTa. As the sequence length doubles from 512 to 1024 tokens, its baseline training time more than triples (increasing from 530s to 1640s), while its corresponding processing throughput collapses to a mere 9,487 tokens/s. Upon reaching the 2048 token threshold, DeBERTa encounters a terminal Out-of-Memory (OOM) failure, illustrated by the sudden truncation in Figure 2 (Right).

In stark contrast, Mamba demonstrates extraordinary memory profile stability. Its active VRAM footprint remains nearly flat, measuring 153MB at 256 tokens versus 151MB at 2048 tokens. Mamba successfully overcomes the 2048-token envelope with a verified inference throughput of 118,000 tokens/s, comfortably bypassing the memory barrier that completely halts traditional dense Transformers. While PatchTST achieves a slightly higher physical throughput at the maximum sequence length, it does so at an unacceptable cost to core classification accuracy.

5 Conclusion

This empirical study highlights the critical trade-offs between semantic predictive power and computational scalability in text classification. Traditional Transformers like DeBERTa offer strong semantic priors but hit a hard computational wall at extended lengths, evidenced by severe throughput degradation and OOM failures at 2048 tokens. Patch-based approximations like PatchTST circumvent the memory crisis but incur significant penalties in classification accuracy due to broken contextual structure.

Mamba emerges as a superior architecture for long-sequence classification, effortlessly maintaining a near-constant VRAM footprint ($\sim 150\text{MB}$) and high operational throughput while achieving competitive and scalable semantic accuracy. Future work will explore scaling pre-trained Mamba architectures to further close the initialization semantic gap with large dense Transformers while fully retaining their profound computational advantages.

References

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